LIVING WITH CHAN

# Against the Current

*How I went from a refugee camp to financial freedom, and why it is not too late for you*



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CALGARY · ALBERTA

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# Dedication

For Mom and Dad, who crossed the river with nothing and gave us everything.

For my sister, who sold lemonade with me through the fence, and who still stands beside me forty years later.

For my husband and my two children. Home is not a place. It is you.

And for every woman who has ever been told she was too late, too different, or too small to build the life she wanted. This book is for you.

# Epigraph

*"I did not want to*
*survive. I wanted to live."*

# A Letter from Chan

Dear friend,

You picked up this book because something in you is asking for more.

Maybe you just turned forty and realized the plan you were following was never really yours. Maybe the kids are getting older and you are wondering what the next chapter looks like. Maybe you are starting over after a divorce, a layoff, a loss, or twenty years of putting everyone else first. Maybe you simply looked at your bank account, then at your calendar, and thought: there has to be another way to do this.

I want you to know something before you read a single page further.

You are not behind. You are not too late. And you are not starting from zero, even when it feels like you are.

I know this because my family arrived in Canada with nothing. Not "nothing" as a figure of speech. Nothing. We escaped a communist country, lived in a refugee camp in Thailand for more than a year, and landed in Calgary in 1980 because a generous family and a church we had never met decided to sponsor strangers. Everything I wore growing up was homemade or secondhand. My first business was a lemonade stand run through a chain-link fence.

And yet, by the time I was twenty-one, I had put together my first real estate deal with none of my own money and no credit. By thirty, the rental properties my partners and I had built paid me more every month than my full-time job did. I have spent more than twenty-five years investing in real estate, helping families buy and sell homes, helping homeowners facing foreclosure walk away with their dignity, and coaching women who were sure they had missed their window.

They had not missed it. Neither have you.

This book is three things at once.

It is a story. My story, and my parents' story before mine, because we are all products of the courage of those who came before us.

It is a set of lessons. Everything the banks and the schools never taught me about money, partnership, and finding out what you are actually worth.

And it is an invitation. At the end of every chapter you will find a few questions. They are not homework. They are the same questions I had to sit with at my own kitchen table, and I promise they will take you somewhere if you let them.

This is not a book about getting rich quickly. It is a book about becoming, slowly and surely, a woman who cannot be stopped.

Pour yourself something warm. Let's begin at the river.

With love and lemonade,

*Chan*

Calgary, Alberta

# How to Read This Book

Read it in order the first time, because the story only makes sense the way it happened: the crossing, the current, the partners, and then your turn.

Keep a pen nearby. The "Your Turn" questions at the end of each chapter are the working heart of this book. Women tell me the questions did more for them than the chapters did, and I take that as a compliment.

And when you finish, pass it on. Give it to your sister, your best friend, the woman at work who keeps saying "someday." This book was always meant to travel from one woman's hands to another's.

PART I

# The Crossing

*Where strength begins*

CHAPTER 1

# The River

I was born in a country that no longer exists the way my parents knew it.

Laos, before the war ended, was my family's whole world: their language, their food, their ancestors, their plans. Then the communists took power, and the plans stopped mattering. My parents faced the kind of decision I hope you never have to face, though I suspect you have faced a version of it. Stay in a life that is slowly closing around you, or leave everything you know for a chance at something you cannot see yet.

They chose to leave.

I was too young to remember most of it myself. What I carry are my parents' memories, told and retold at our kitchen table over the years: the leaving, the fear, the border, and then the waiting. We spent more than a year in a refugee camp in Thailand. A year of lining up, of not knowing, of my mother and father holding a family together inside a fence with nothing to offer us but themselves.

Here is what I want you to understand about that year. My parents were not waiting passively. They were holding a decision. Every single day in that camp, they renewed the same choice: we are going somewhere better, and we are arriving there together. That is what courage actually looks like. It is rarely one

dramatic moment. It is the same unglamorous choice, made again every morning, long after the adrenaline is gone.

In 1980, the miracle came in the most ordinary form imaginable: paperwork. A generous family and a church congregation in Canada, people who had never met us and owed us nothing, sponsored my family. Strangers signed their names for us. Because they did, I grew up in Calgary, Alberta, and I have now lived here for more than forty-five years.

I tell you this story first, before the real estate, before the deals, before any of it, for one reason.

Every woman I coach believes, somewhere deep down, that the successful women she admires started with something she does not have. More money. Better connections. A luckier family. A younger start. I need you to know that my starting line was a refugee camp, and that the first investors in my life were strangers from a church who decided a family they had never met was worth betting on.

You are not behind those women. You are simply earlier in your own story than they are in theirs.

And there is a second lesson hiding in the river crossing, one it took me decades to see. My parents did not cross alone. Nobody does. They were carried by boat pilots and border guides, by aid workers in the camp, by a sponsoring family and a church full of volunteers on the other side of the world. The bravest act of self-reliance in my family's history was also, from beginning to end, a partnership.

Hold onto that. It is the seed of everything this book will ask of you.

YOUR TURN

1. What "river" are you standing in front of right now: the change you know you need to make but have not yet committed to?
2. Courage is a daily renewal, not a single leap. What is one choice you could renew every morning for the next year?
3. Who has quietly "sponsored" you in your life so far? Who signed their name for you? What did that teach you about accepting help?

CHAPTER 2

# Lemonade Through the Fence

Everything in our house was homemade or secondhand.

I do not say that for sympathy. I say it because for years I was embarrassed by it, and now I understand it was the most valuable business education money could not buy. When nothing is handed to you, you learn to see resources where other people see nothing. You learn that between "we cannot afford it" and "we will figure it out" there is an entire universe, and your family lives or dies by which sentence they choose.

My parents chose "we will figure it out." Every time.

My favourite proof is a chain-link fence.

Our family lived near the Shaganappi golf course in Calgary. My sister and I were little girls with no allowance, no store, and no permission slip from anyone. What we had was a hot summer, a fence, and a steady supply of thirsty golfers walking past on the other side of it.

So we made lemonade, and we sold it through the fence.

Think about everything wrapped up inside that little enterprise. We found a customer with a need. We positioned ourselves exactly where the customer already was. We used the resources we had instead of waiting for the ones we wished for. We

handled money, made change, managed inventory on a hot day, and split the take with a partner. Two immigrant kids ran the whole cycle of a business through the gaps in a chain-link fence, and we thought we were just playing.

Forty years later, I stood beside that same sister at a Canada Day festival in Medicine Hat, launching a real beverage company together, our daughters working the booth beside us. I will tell you that story properly near the end of this book, because it made me cry then and it makes me cry now. But I mention it here so you can see what I see: the fence was not a small thing. The fence was the first thing. Every big thing in my life started as a small thing that I refused to treat as small.

Now let me turn this toward you, because you have your own fence, and I suspect you cannot see it yet.

Women between thirty and sixty are the most resourceful human beings on this planet, and the least likely to give themselves credit for it. You run households on budgets that would terrify a CFO. You negotiate daily with toddlers, teenagers, contractors, schools, and aging parents. You coordinate schedules that look like air traffic control. You have been buying and selling, borrowing and lending, budgeting and forecasting your entire adult life. You just never called it business.

When a woman tells me, "Chan, I don't have any experience," what she almost always means is, "Nobody ever paid me a salary for the experience I have." Those are very different sentences.

Scarcity taught me creativity. Responsibility taught you management. Neither of us got the certificate, and neither of us needed it.

YOUR TURN

1. Write down three problems you solved in the last month without spending money. That is resourcefulness. Where else could it be pointed?
2. What was your "lemonade stand"? Somewhere in your past there is a moment you created value out of nothing. What did it feel like?
3. What skills do you use every week that you have never given yourself professional credit for? List five. Do not stop at three.

CHAPTER 3

# Home Is the People

My parents never had much money to give us, so they gave us beliefs instead. Looking back, I got the better end of that trade.

The first belief was gratitude. My parents taught me to love Canada, imperfections and all, the way you love family: honestly, loyally, and without pretending it is flawless. They never let us forget the government that opened the door in those years, or the family and the church who sponsored us. Whatever this country asked of us, we would give it, because we knew exactly what the alternative had been. Canada will always be in my heart. No matter what.

The second belief was unity. We did not have the newest anything. What we had, always, was each other. Through the camp, through the early years of being new and broke and foreign, through my parents' later health battles, the family held. My parents taught me that home is not a place. Home is the people.

I want to sit with that sentence, because it eventually became the foundation of my entire career, and I did not see it coming.

I have spent more than twenty-five years around real estate. Houses, duplexes, rentals, renovations, foreclosures, closings. From the outside it looks like an industry about buildings. It is not. I have handed keys to first-time buyers who cried in the

driveway. I have sat at kitchen tables with families about to lose their homes to foreclosure and helped them find a way to leave with money in their pockets and their heads held high. I have watched empty rooms become the backdrop of someone's whole life.

Not once, in all those years, was the transaction really about the building. It was about the people inside it and what they were trying to protect, start, survive, or become.

This matters for you, and here is why.

Somewhere along the way, someone convinced women that ambition is selfish. That wanting money is unbecoming. That investing is what other people do, colder people, usually men in suits. So we hesitate, we defer, we wait for permission that never comes.

But if home is the people, then building wealth is not selfish at all. It is shelter-building. When I bought my first rental property, I was not collecting a trophy. I was making sure that what happened to my parents, arriving at midlife with nothing, could never happen to my children. Every property since has been another wall against the storm, for my family and for the tenant family living inside it.

Your reason will be your own. Your daughter's education. Your own dignity in retirement. The ability to leave a job, or a marriage, that is slowly making you smaller. The freedom to care for your parents the way they cared for you.

Find your people. Then build for them. Ambition rooted in love is not greed. It is the oldest, most honourable work there is.

YOUR TURN

1. Who are your people, the ones you are really building for? Name them. Write the names down where you will see them.
2. Complete this sentence honestly: "If money were not a limit, I would protect my people by..."
3. What belief about money did you inherit from your childhood home? Is it serving you, or do you need to hand it back with thanks?

PART II

# Against The Current

*Finding your way when the way was not built for you*

CHAPTER 4

# The Only Woman in the Room

I have a confession: I was a reckless, chaotic student.

Not reckless in the way that ruins lives. Reckless in the way that refuses to sit still inside someone else's plan. If everyone was walking one direction, I felt an almost physical pull to walk the other way, just to see what was over there. For years I thought this was a flaw I needed to fix. It turned out to be the engine of my whole life.

At university, I wanted a challenge. I was ambitious and hungry, so I aimed at one of the hardest programs I could find: chemical engineering. I climbed. I did well. And then, halfway up the mountain, I discovered a terrible secret that nobody warns overachievers about.

I was bored.

Not struggling. Bored. There is a difference, and it took me a long time to respect it. Struggle means you are growing. Boredom means you are dying quietly in a room that looks like success. So I did the thing good immigrant daughters are absolutely not supposed to do.

I dropped out.

I can still feel the weight of that decision. My parents had crossed a river and an ocean so their children could have exactly this kind of education, and here I was walking away from it. But I was not walking away from effort. I was walking toward a bigger fight. I set my eyes on petroleum engineering, an even harder program, and I made it in.

There was one detail about that program that everyone around me saw as a problem: I was the only woman in it.

The only one. Every classroom, every lab, every study group: me and the men.

And here is the part of my story that I need you to hear exactly as I mean it. I loved it. The odds stacked against me were not the price of admission. They were the attraction. I loved being the stone in the current. I loved swimming against the ocean. Where other people saw isolation, I saw distinction. Nobody forgot who I was. Nobody confused me with anyone else. Every room I walked into, I had already done something the men in it had not: I had walked in anyway.

Years later I understood that this was not really about engineering at all. University was a training ground for what came next, because a woman building wealth in the 1990s walked into the only-woman-in-the-room experience over and over. Bankers' offices. Investor meetings. Renovation sites. Negotiation tables. If I had waited for those rooms to look like me before I entered them, I would still be waiting.

So let me hand you the three things being the only woman in the room taught me, because you will need them.

First, being different is not a limitation. It is freedom. When you do not fit the mold, you are excused from the mold. Nobody expects you to do it the standard way, which means you are free to do it your way. From the humblest of beginnings, I can tell you: being different does not make you limited. It gives you the freedom to become anything you want.

Second, discomfort is information, not instruction. The knot in your stomach when you are the only woman at the investors' meetup does not mean "leave." It means "you are somewhere new." Those are not the same message. Learn to tell them apart and half your fear becomes fuel.

Third, boredom is a compass. If you are excellent at something that is slowly putting you to sleep, you are not obligated to keep doing it. Yes, even at forty-five. Especially at forty-five. Quitting the wrong mountain is not failure. It is navigation.

YOUR TURN

1. Where in your life are you succeeding at something that bores you? Be honest. What would "walking toward a bigger fight" look like?
2. Recall a time you were the "only one" in a room: the only woman, the only newcomer, the only one without the credential. What did you do that you are proud of?
3. What rule were you raised to follow that you have secretly outgrown?

CHAPTER 5

# When Everything Falls Apart

Every woman I have ever coached has a chapter like this one. If you have not lived yours yet, you will, and I say that not to frighten you but to prepare you: the worst season of your life may also be the one that finally sets you in motion.

Mine came when my parents' health collapsed.

They were both in critical condition. We were still a young immigrant family, not long in Canada, without deep savings, without a professional network, without a safety net of any kind. My sister and I looked at each other and understood, without saying it out loud, that the two little girls who sold lemonade through the fence were now responsible for sustaining the family.

I remember the fear. But more than the fear, I remember a kind of terrible clarity. Desperation strips away every polite fiction about how life works. It showed me the truth: I could spend the next forty years trading my hours for dollars, always one crisis away from the edge, exactly as vulnerable as we were at that moment. Or I could find another way.

That was the moment my entrepreneurship journey actually began. Not with a vision board. Not with a seminar. With a hospital, a stack of bills, and a question I could not put down:

How can I build income that does not require me to trade my life away to earn it?

I want to be careful here, because I know who is reading this book. You may be in your own falling-apart season right now. A divorce that rewrote your future. A layoff at fifty. A diagnosis, yours or someone you love. Parents who suddenly need you the way you once needed them. If that is you, I am not going to insult you with "everything happens for a reason." Some things just hurt, and you are allowed to say so.

What I will tell you is what I found on the other side of my season.

I did not want to survive. I wanted to live.

That sentence became the dividing line of my life. Survival is what you do when you accept the terms you were handed. Living is what happens when you renegotiate them. Surviving asked me: how do I cover this month? Living asked me: how do I make sure no month ever owns me again?

Notice what changed. The crisis did not give me resources. We were as broke after my parents got sick as before. What the crisis gave me was a question, and a reason strong enough to carry it. My why was lying in a hospital bed. Everything I built afterward, every property, every business, every risk, traces back to that room.

Here is what I know now, twenty-five years and many storms later. Pain is a terrible master but an extraordinary fuel. I took all of the pain my family had experienced, the war, the camp, the poverty, the hospital, and I used it as the raw material for a

future none of it predicted. Not because I am special. Because I finally had a reason bigger than my fear.

Your crisis is asking you a question. Most people only hear the noise. Listen for the question.

YOUR TURN

1. What is, or was, your falling-apart season? Write it down plainly, without softening it.
2. What question is that season asking you? Not "why me," but "what now."
3. Complete this sentence: "I do not want to survive. I want to..." Keep writing until something on the page makes your heart beat faster.

CHAPTER 6

# No Money, No Credit, No Permission

At twenty-one years old, I put together my first real estate deal: a detached home in Calgary.

I had no money of my own in it. I had no credit. What I had was a problem worth solving, the willingness to learn in public, and the humility to bring other people into what I could not do alone.

Now, this is the part of my story where people usually lean in and ask for the mechanics. What clause? What structure? And there are answers, an entire toolbox of them: seller financing, joint ventures, assumable mortgages, rent-to-own, partnerships where one person brings capital and the other brings the deal and the work. Creative financing is real, it is learnable, and I have spent decades using it and teaching it.

But if I give you the mechanics before the principle, I will have wasted this chapter, because the mechanics change with every market and the principle never does. So here is the principle.

**Every deal is a table with several seats, and you only need to fill one of them.**

A real estate deal needs money. It needs credit. It needs knowledge. It needs time and effort. It needs the deal itself, meaning someone who found the opportunity. And it needs trust, the glue that lets strangers cooperate. Six seats. The lie that stops most women is the belief that they must fill all six seats alone before they are allowed to begin. So they wait. They wait until they have the down payment and the perfect credit score and the confidence, and somewhere in the waiting, a decade quietly disappears.

At twenty-one I could fill exactly two seats. I had found an opportunity, and I was willing to do the work no one else wanted to do. Money? Someone else had that. Credit? Someone else had that too. The question was never "do I have everything?" The question was "who has the rest, and why would they want to sit at a table with me?"

The answer to that second question is the most liberating thing I will tell you in this book: people with money are looking for people with problems solved. Capital is abundant and initiative is rare, which means the person who brings a well-prepared opportunity to the table is not begging. She is offering.

I did not know any of this as theory back then. I learned it by doing it scared. My hands shook. I said "I don't know, but I will find out" more times than I could count. I let people who knew more than me check my work, and some of the correction stung. The deal closed anyway. A girl who grew up in hand-me-downs, whose family had arrived with nothing, controlled a house in Calgary before she could legally rent a car in some countries.

And the strangest thing happened in the weeks after. Nothing outside me changed, but everything inside me did. The world had been divided into people who do these things and people like me. That line turned out to be imaginary. I had drawn it myself, and I could erase it myself.

You have a version of that line. Everyone does. Mine said "girls from refugee camps don't own real estate." Yours might say "women my age don't start over" or "I'm not a numbers person" or "people like me don't ask rich people for anything." Whatever it says, the line is drawn in the same washable ink mine was.

No money is a problem with a hundred known solutions. No credit is a problem with a hundred known solutions. No permission? That one is not even a problem. Nobody was ever going to give it to you anyway. It was always yours to give yourself.

YOUR TURN

1. Look at the six seats: money, credit, knowledge, time and effort, the found opportunity, and trust. Which two can you fill today? Be generous with yourself and honest.
2. Whose "table" could you add real value to right now, even without money?
3. Write out your imaginary line: "People like me don't..." Now write the name of one real woman who did it anyway. If you cannot name one, you have not looked yet. Go look.

CHAPTER 7

# Paid While You Sleep

By the time I was thirty, something quietly historic had happened in my family, and almost nobody knew about it.

The rental properties I had built and partnered into across Calgary and Saskatoon were paying me more every month than my full-time job. Positive cashflow, month after month, arriving whether I got out of bed or not. In one generation, my family had gone from a refugee camp to owning income that worked while we slept.

I need to tell you what that actually felt like, because the number was never the point.

It felt like exhaling. For the first time in my life, and if I am honest, for the first time in my family's remembered history, the ground was not moving. A job loss could not sink us. A crisis could not undo us the way my parents' illness nearly had. When I walked into my job, I walked in by choice, and everyone can feel the difference between a woman who is there by choice and a woman who is trapped. So can she.

This is what I mean when I say wealth, and I want to define it carefully, because the world has handed women some very silly definitions.

Wealth is not a handbag. It is not a number chosen to impress strangers. Wealth is options. It is the ability to say no: to a bad boss, a bad deal, a bad situation that a paycheque used to force you to tolerate. It is the ability to say yes: to your daughter's opportunity, to your parents' care, to your own rest. Cashflow is simply freedom, paid monthly.

And for women, cashflow is something more. It is safety. I have sat with too many women who stayed too long in jobs and marriages and circumstances that diminished them, not because they could not see the exit, but because they could not afford it. I do not judge a single one of them. I simply want the next generation of women, and I mean you, to hold the key to their own doors.

There is a second thing I learned in those years, and it changed how I see money forever: real estate done right is not extraction. It is service, paid well.

Some of the most meaningful work of my career has been with homeowners facing foreclosure. Families out of options, ashamed, hiding letters from the bank. The banks would not teach them their choices, and the schools never had. I could sit at their kitchen table and show them a way to stop the foreclosure, maximize what their home returned to them, and walk out with dignity instead of being carried out by a process. I made a living. They kept their self-respect and often a meaningful cheque. Both things were true at once, and I stopped apologizing for that a long time ago.

Whatever you were taught, money earned by solving real problems for real people is honourable. A woman with cashflow

is not less kind, less feminine, or less devoted to her family. She is more dangerous to every circumstance that used to push her around. That is the whole idea.

One warning before we move on, because I promised you honesty. Passive income is not passive at the beginning. Those properties were bought with years of learning, unglamorous work, tenant calls, and mistakes I paid tuition on. The freedom of my thirties was purchased by the discipline of my twenties. There is no version of this story without the work. There is only the choice of which decade does the paying: an early one, on your terms, or every decade, on someone else's.

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YOUR TURN

1. What would "the ability to say no" change in your life, specifically? Name the first no you would say.
2. Look at your current income. If life paused you for six months, what would keep arriving? What is one step toward changing that answer?
3. What belief do you carry about women and money that you would never allow someone to say about your daughter or your best friend?

PART III

# Stronger Together

*The power of partnership, and how to find your seat at the table*

CHAPTER 8

# Never Judge a Book

I have to tell you about a flaw of mine, because overcoming it built my career, and I see the same flaw quietly costing women everywhere.

I used to judge books by their covers. People, I mean. I would take one look and decide who was worth listening to. The polished ones, the credentialed ones, the ones who looked like success as I imagined it: those were the teachers. Everyone else was background.

Life corrected me, repeatedly and without mercy.

Some of the most important lessons of my investing life came from people I had almost dismissed. The landlord in the worn jacket who owned half a street. The quiet woman at the back of the meeting who had renovated more houses than everyone talking at the front. The seller across the kitchen table who taught me more about negotiation by watching him than any course ever did. You can never know a story until you read it yourself. Covers lie in both directions: they hide wisdom, and they dress up noise.

The day I finally learned this was one of the true beginnings of my success, and the lesson has a name. It is called humility, and it is not what most people think.

Humility is not thinking less of yourself. I want to be very clear with you about that, because women have been handed enough smallness for one century. Humility is the discipline of stepping aside, closing your mouth, and opening your ears to people who know more than you and have what you want. That is the whole practice. It costs nothing, it is available to everyone, and it is shockingly rare.

Here is why it is rare: listening feels like losing. When someone corrects your numbers or questions your plan, everything in you wants to defend, explain, prove. I had that instinct in abundance. I was ambitious, an overachiever, allergic to being wrong. Learning to say five simple words, "teach me, I'm listening," felt at first like swallowing stones. It turned out to be swallowing keys.

Because look at what listening actually buys you. Every person who has already walked your road is carrying a map. Most of them, and this surprised me, are happy to share it. People love to teach what they have mastered; they are just tired of teaching people who will not hear them. When you become a woman who genuinely listens, mentors find you. Doors you did not knock on start opening from the inside.

There is a flip side to this chapter, and it belongs to you especially.

You will be judged by your cover too. As a woman, and in my case a female immigrant with an accent and a name nobody could pronounce, you will walk into rooms where someone has already decided your story without reading it. Chan-SU-da. I

have watched people's eyes slide past me toward whichever man in the room looked more like their idea of an investor.

I used to resent it. Then I learned to use it.

Being underestimated is a strategic gift. The underestimated woman gets to watch, listen, and learn while everyone else performs. She hears the honest numbers because nobody bothers to posture for her. And when she finally moves, she moves with information the posturers gave away for free. Some of my best deals were built in rooms where I was invisible right up until the moment I wasn't.

So carry both halves of this lesson together. Read others slowly, generously, past their covers, because teachers rarely look like teachers. And when others read you wrongly, do not waste your energy correcting the review. Let them keep their cheap edition of you. The full story is none of their business until it is standing at the closing table.

YOUR TURN

1. Who in your life have you been dismissing by their cover? What might they know that you need?
2. When were you last genuinely corrected, and how did you respond? What would "teach me, I'm listening" cost you? What might it buy?
3. Recall a moment you were underestimated. What information or freedom did it actually hand you, and did you use it?

CHAPTER 9

# What You Bring to the Table

If I could sit across from you with two cups of tea and ask one question, it would be this: what do you think you bring to the table?

I have asked hundreds of women some version of it. The answers break my heart a little every time. "Honestly, not much yet." "I'm still learning." "I'd mostly need other people to carry me at first." Then I ask the same woman about her life, and within ten minutes she has casually described managing renovations, untangling a parent's estate, running a school fundraiser that raised more than some small businesses earn, negotiating a car purchase, keeping a household solvent through a layoff, and talking a teenager off three separate ledges.

Not much yet.

We established the six seats at every deal's table back in Chapter 6: money, credit, knowledge, time and effort, the found opportunity, and trust. Now I want to show you where women fit at that table, because it is almost never where they assume.

Most women assume their seat is "none, until I have money." But money is the most replaceable seat at the table. I say that as someone who has raised it, borrowed it, and partnered for it: capital is a commodity. It has no ideas, finds no deals, and fixes no problems at two a.m. Every serious investor I know has more

capital than good opportunities and trustworthy people to share them with. Read that sentence again, because it is the quiet engine of this whole book.

The scarce seats, the ones people compete to fill, are the human ones. And they happen to be the ones women have been unknowingly training for their entire lives.

**Trust.** Deals are made of promises kept over years. Who gets invited back, again and again, is the person others can rely on. Women build and maintain webs of trust as naturally as breathing; we have been the keepers of families, friendships, and communities forever. In business this is not a soft skill. It is the load-bearing wall.

**Diligence.** The unglamorous work of reading every page, checking every number, asking the awkward question. The same attention that catches a permission slip due Friday catches a clause that would have cost a partnership fifty thousand dollars.

**Relationships.** Deals travel through people: the neighbour who mentions a house before it lists, the mortgage broker who calls you first, the widow who will only sell to someone she likes. Women build these networks constantly and call it "just staying in touch."

**Judgment.** Decades of running a life teach pattern recognition no spreadsheet holds: which contractor is lying, which tenant is struggling versus scamming, which partner's charm has a smell to it. In my experience, a seasoned woman's read on people outperforms almost any model.

**Care.** The rarest one. Most people in any transaction are trying to get through it. The person who genuinely cares how it lands for everyone becomes the person everyone wants at their table. Care, at scale, is a business model. It has been mine for twenty-five years.

Notice what is on that list. Notice that not one item requires a finance degree, a six-figure account, or anyone's permission. You have been acquiring the scarce assets while apologizing for lacking the common one.

So here is your homework, and unlike the money, it cannot be borrowed. Take inventory. Honestly, on paper, tally what thirty or forty or fifty years of life have actually deposited in you. Then, and this is the hard part, practice saying it out loud without an apology attached. Not "I'm just really organized," but "I run diligence; nothing gets past me." Not "people seem to trust me for some reason," but "I keep promises, and my track record is my collateral."

The table is real, the seats are real, and one of them has been yours for years. The only thing missing has been your signature.

YOUR TURN

1. Score yourself, one to ten, on each of the six seats: money, credit, knowledge, time and effort, finding opportunities, and trust. Where are you strongest? Does your answer surprise you?
2. Write down your "invisible resume": five things you have managed, negotiated, saved, or rebuilt that never appeared on any CV.
3. Practice one sentence that states your strength without apology. Say it out loud until it stops feeling like bragging and starts feeling like fact.

CHAPTER 10

# Partners, Sisters, and Lemonade Again

Nothing I have built, I built alone. I want that sentence near the front of this chapter because our culture keeps selling women the self-made myth, and the myth is not just false. It is expensive. It keeps you waiting until you can do everything yourself, which is another way of saying it keeps you waiting forever.

My family crossed the river with partners. My first deal at twenty-one existed because partners filled the seats I could not. The portfolio that freed me by thirty was a braid of joint ventures, lenders, mentors, tradespeople, and one very patient sister. So let me tell you what twenty-five years of partnering has taught me, the beautiful and the painful, and then I will tell you about the lemonade.

**Choose character first, competence second, chemistry third.** A skilled partner without integrity is simply a sophisticated way to lose money. A delightful partner without follow-through is a slow way to lose it. Watch how a potential partner treats waiters, tenants, and people they outrank. Watch what they do when a small thing goes wrong. Small storms forecast big ones.

**Put everything in writing, especially with people you love.** Women resist this one hardest, because it feels like distrust. Hear

me: paper is not distrust. Paper is kindness with a long memory. A clear written agreement about money, roles, decisions, and exits is how you guarantee that the deal, however it goes, will not cost you the relationship. The handshake protects nothing but the moment. My rule is simple: if we cannot discuss the agreement while we like each other, we certainly cannot discuss the disaster after we don't.

**Complement, don't duplicate.** The best partnerships pair differences: her capital with your hustle, her caution with your courage, her spreadsheet with your people-sense. If you and a potential partner bring identical strengths, you have doubled your blind spots, not your power.

**Start small on purpose.** Do a small thing together before a big thing. A tiny flip before a building. One event before a company. Partnership is a muscle you test with light weights first.

**And keep your own name on your own life.** Partnering is not merging. You can share a deal without surrendering your judgment, your signature, or your voice. The moment a partnership requires you to become smaller to keep the peace, the price has exceeded any possible return. I have walked away from money to keep myself. I have never once regretted it.

Now the lemonade.

Forty years after two little immigrant girls sold lemonade through the chain-link fence at the Shaganappi golf course, my sister and I stood side by side again. Canada Day, Kin Coulee Park, Medicine Hat. This time the stand had a name, Orchid Tap Bar, and a menu we had refined ourselves: nitro cold brew that sold out completely, nitro matcha we ran out of twice, and a

strawberry-lemon creation called The Shag that stole the whole show. And working the booth beside us, laughing, pouring, learning to make change on a hot day, were our daughters.

Some dreams really do come full circle.

I stood there in the noise of the festival and cried a little, and I did not care who saw, because I could see all of it at once: the fence, the camp, our parents' hands, the decades of separate battles my sister and I had fought, and now our girls, third generation, learning through their fingertips the same lesson we learned through ours. Family is the first partnership. If you are lucky, and if you tend it, it can also be the longest.

That day was not about beverages, just as the fence was never about lemonade. It was about what two women can build when they stop waiting and start pouring. Every event since, we have improved something. That is the other secret of partnership, by the way: you do not have to launch perfectly. You have to launch together, and learn fast.

We are just getting started. So, I suspect, are you.

YOUR TURN

1. Think of the best team you have ever been part of, in any context. What made it work? What seat did you hold?
2. Who are three women you could realistically build something with? What would each of you bring? What small thing could you attempt together first?
3. Have you ever stayed small to keep a relationship peaceful? What did it cost? What would "keeping your own name on your own life" require you to change?

PART IV

# Your Turn

*It is not too late. It was never too late.*

CHAPTER 11

# It's Not Too Late

Let me guess the sentence you have been carrying while you read this book. It goes something like: "This is beautiful, Chan, but you started at twenty-one. I'm forty-seven."

Sit down with me. We need to talk about time.

Yes, I created my first deal at twenty-one. Do you know what I brought to that deal besides courage? Nothing. No money, no credit, no track record, no network, no judgment. I had never managed a household budget through a recession. I had never read people across a negotiation table, hired a contractor, survived a bad boss, raised a child, or buried a fear. Twenty-one-year-old Chan had exactly two assets: time and nerve.

Now look at yourself honestly, you at thirty-eight or forty-seven or fifty-six, and take the same inventory. You have decades of pattern recognition that no course can teach. You know when a person is lying to you; it took me years and money to learn that. You may have equity in a home, a retirement account, or simply a credit history, all of which are seats at the table that young Chan had to borrow from strangers. You have a network you do not even recognize as a network: coworkers, school parents, church friends, cousins, every one of them a possible partner, teacher, or connection. And you have something younger

women rarely have: you know who you are. Do you have any idea how much money that self-knowledge saves?

The math our culture teaches women about age is simply wrong. It counts the years behind you as spent. They are not spent. They are invested, and you are walking around with the compounded returns: judgment, relationships, resilience, and the priceless ability to tell what matters from what glitters.

And the years ahead? Count them properly too. A woman of forty-five may have forty more years. Forty years is not a remnant. It is an entire second lifetime, longer than most empires of industry took to build. If you bought one modest rental property every few years for even a third of it, you would change your family's story permanently. The question was never how many years you have. It is what the next one is for.

I have watched this play out in real women, not theory. The ones who start at forty and fifty often outperform the ones who start at twenty-five, and there are reasons. They waste less time on ego. They do diligence like their life depends on it, because they know exactly what a setback costs. They pick better partners, having survived a few wrong ones in other arenas. Their "why" is not vague ambition; it is specific and burning: this daughter, this retirement, this freedom, this never-again.

There is one more thing I want to dismantle before you turn the page, and it is tender, so I will be gentle. Somewhere under "it's too late" usually lives a quieter sentence: "I don't deserve to start over." Women carry this one especially. We are so practiced at being the resource for everyone else that spending resources on our own becoming feels like theft.

It is not theft. Listen to an immigrant daughter on this. My parents crossed a river in the dark so that the women of this family could do exactly what you are hesitating to do: begin. Every woman who begins, at any age, honours every woman who never got the chance. Your beginning is not selfish. It is the point of all the sacrifice that came before you, whoever made it.

The current does not check your birthdate before it lets you swim. I promise. I have been swimming against it my whole life, and it has never once asked my age.

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YOUR TURN

1. Write your real inventory at your current age: judgment, network, capital, credit, skills, self-knowledge. Compare it honestly to what a twenty-one-year-old has. Who would you rather bet on?
2. How many years might you realistically have ahead? Write the number. What could that "second lifetime" hold if you gave it a direction this year?
3. Whose sacrifice does your beginning honour? Write her name. Begin for her if you cannot yet begin for yourself.

CHAPTER 12

# Begin Where You Are

Every book like this one faces the same danger in its final chapter. You close the cover, feel wonderful for two days, and change nothing. I refuse to let that happen to us. So this chapter is not a send-off. It is a beginning, laid out in six moves, none of which require money, and all of which require you.

**Move one: write your why where you can see it.** Not "financial freedom." Something with faces in it. My why had a hospital room in it, and my parents' hands. Yours might have a daughter's tuition, a mortgage-free sixtieth birthday, the ability to leave, or the ability to stay on your own terms. You will not outwork fear with willpower. You will outwork it with a reason. Get the reason on paper first, everything else second.

**Move two: learn the language, one hour a week.** Real estate, like every world that guards its doors, runs on vocabulary: cashflow, equity, appreciation, amortization, cap rate, joint venture. None of it is difficult. It is just unfamiliar, and unfamiliarity is what gets mistaken for "not for me." One hour a week, a book, a podcast on your commute, a library course. In six months you will follow any conversation. In a year you will notice something shocking: you can tell when the confident man at the front of the room is wrong.

**Move three: audit your six seats.** You did this in Chapter 9 if you did the work; if not, tonight is a fine night. Money, credit, knowledge, time and effort, opportunity-finding, trust. Two lists: what I have, what I need. This turns the fog of "someday" into a shopping list, and shopping lists get filled.

**Move four: find your people.** Nothing about this path requires you to walk it alone, and almost everything gets easier in company. Every city, Calgary very much included, has real estate meetups, women's investing circles, and rooms full of people trading what they know. Walk in. Yes, the first time is uncomfortable. Go anyway, and go twice, because the second visit is when strangers become familiar. And remember what you learned about the only woman in the room: if that is you, wonderful. Nobody will forget you.

**Move five: talk to women who have done it.** Not to pitch. To listen. Buy a coffee for a woman who owns a rental, who flipped a house, who invests with her sister. Ask her what she wishes she had known. Women who have crossed the water almost always turn around to help the next one across; I have built a career on being that woman, and I am far from the only one. One honest hour with someone six steps ahead of you is worth a shelf of theory.

**Move six: do one small brave thing this month.** Not someday. This month. Walk through an open house and let yourself feel what it would mean to be there as an investor. Ask your bank one question you have been avoiding. Attend one meetup. Make one call. The size of the step matters far less than its direction, because motion creates evidence, and evidence is the only thing that ever truly kills fear. The lemonade stand was small. The first

deal was one house. Everything begins embarrassingly small, and then it does not stay small.

That is the whole system. No secrets withheld for a seminar. A woman with a why, a growing vocabulary, an honest inventory, a room of people, a mentor's coffee cup, and one brave step a month is not "getting ready" to change her life. She is already changing it, and within a year she will be unrecognizable to her own doubts.

I want to leave you with the picture I keep on the wall of my mind.

A little girl stands at a chain-link fence with a pitcher of lemonade her mother helped her make from almost nothing. On the other side of the fence is a world that has all the money, all the credit, all the confidence, all the things she does not have. She has a paper cup and a decision.

She does not wait for a gate.

She pours through the fence.

Every single thing in my life came through that gap in the wire: the houses, the freedom, the businesses, the full-circle Canada Day with my sister and our daughters. Not because the fence disappeared. Fences never fully disappear, not for women, not for immigrants, not for anyone starting with less. You do not need the fence to disappear. You need a pitcher, a cup, and the nerve to call out to the people walking past.

You have all three. You always did.

Pour.

YOUR TURN

1. Which of the six moves will you make first, and on what date? Write the date. A move without a date is a wish.
2. What is your "one small brave thing" this month? Tell one person about it today, because spoken intentions survive.
3. One year from now, what would you love to write to me about? Write that letter now, in two paragraphs, dated one year ahead. Keep it somewhere safe. I am serious about this one.

EPILOGUE

# Full Circle

On Canada Day, in Kin Coulee Park, between the music and the crowds, I watched my niece hand a stranger a cup of The Shag and say thank you with her whole face, and for one moment I could see the entire river at once.

My parents, deciding in the dark to leave everything.

A church full of strangers, signing their names for a family they had never met.

Two little girls at a fence, counting coins into a jar.

A hospital room, and a question that would not let me go.

A twenty-one-year-old with no money and no credit, signing her first deal with a shaking hand.

A thirty-year-old checking her mail and realizing, quietly, that she was free.

Two sisters, forty years later, sold out of nitro cold brew and laughing about it, their daughters beside them.

We are all products of the courage of those who came before us. But courage is not only something you inherit. It is something you deposit, every time you begin something scared, for the

women who come after you, whether they share your blood or only your hope.

This book was my deposit.

Your move, my friend. The water is cold, the current is real, and you were built for it.

I will see you on the other side of the river.

*Chan*

# Ten Things I Would Tell My Younger Self

*(and every woman reading this)*

1. **You are not behind.** There is no schedule. There is only your river and your crossing.
2. **Boredom is a compass, not a character flaw.** If success is putting you to sleep, you climbed the wrong mountain. Climb down and pick another. That is navigation, not failure.
3. **Being the only woman in the room is a position of strength.** You will be remembered, you will be underestimated, and both are useful.
4. **Money is the most replaceable seat at the table.** Trust, diligence, judgment, and care are the scarce ones. You already own them.
5. **Ask "teach me, I'm listening" early and often.** Every year you delay humility, you pay full tuition for lessons someone would have given you for coffee.
6. **Put every agreement in writing, especially with people you love.** Paper is not distrust. Paper is kindness with a long memory.
7. **Never trade your name for a partnership's peace.** The moment you must become smaller to keep something, it has already cost more than it can return.

8. **Your pain is raw material.** You do not have to be grateful for it. You only have to refuse to waste it.
9. **Do it scared.** Confidence is not the entry requirement. It is the graduation gift. Motion creates evidence, and evidence kills fear.
10. **Home is not a place. It is the people.** Build for them, with them, and you will never once wonder whether the work was worth it.

# Your Journal: All the Questions in One Place

Use these pages slowly. One honest answer is worth more than a finished workbook.

## The Crossing

- What "river" are you standing in front of right now?
- What is one choice you could renew every morning for the next year?
- Who has quietly sponsored you in your life, and what did it teach you about accepting help?
- What was your lemonade stand, the moment you created value out of nothing?
- What skills do you use weekly that you have never given yourself professional credit for?
- Who are your people, the ones you are really building for?
- What belief about money did you inherit, and is it serving you?

## Against the Current

- Where are you succeeding at something that bores you?

- What rule were you raised to follow that you have secretly outgrown?
- What is, or was, your falling-apart season, and what question is it asking you?
- Complete the sentence: "I do not want to survive. I want to..."
- Of the six seats (money, credit, knowledge, time and effort, opportunity, trust), which two can you fill today?
- Write your imaginary line: "People like me don't..." Then name one woman who did it anyway.
- What would the ability to say no change in your life, specifically?
- If life paused you for six months, what income would keep arriving?

## Stronger Together

- Who have you been dismissing by their cover, and what might they know that you need?
- When were you last underestimated, and what did it actually hand you?
- What is your invisible resume: five things you managed, negotiated, saved, or rebuilt that never appeared on a CV?
- What is one sentence that states your strength without apology?
- Who are three women you could build something with, and what small thing could you attempt first?

- Have you ever stayed small to keep the peace? What did it cost?

## Your Turn

- What does your real inventory look like at your current age, and who would you rather bet on?
- Whose sacrifice does your beginning honour?
- Which of the six moves comes first, and on what date?
- What is your one small brave thing this month, and who will you tell today?
- Write the letter you hope to send one year from now. Date it. Keep it.

# About Chan

**Chansouda "Chan" Kawaguchi** arrived in Canada in 1980 as a child refugee from Laos, after her family escaped a communist regime and spent more than a year in a Thai refugee camp before being sponsored by a Canadian family and church. She has called Calgary home for more than forty-five years.

She created her first real estate deal at age twenty-one with none of her own money or credit. By thirty, her rental properties in Calgary and Saskatoon paid her more each month than her full-time job. Over more than twenty-five years in real estate investing, Chan has used creative financing strategies to help homeowners stop foreclosures and sell with dignity, while teaching others what the banks and schools never will about money. In 2016 she became the number one insurance agent in Canada within six months of entering outside sales. She solves problems for a living, coaches real estate investors, and is devoted to inspiring women entrepreneurs.

Chan is a REMAX Complete Realty real estate agent serving Calgary, Alberta and surrounding communities. She is a wife, a mother of two, a golfer, a weekly pickleball player (ask her why both are like real estate), and co-founder, with her sister, of Orchid Tap Bar: the grown-up version of the lemonade stand they ran as little girls through the fence at the Shaganappi golf course.

## Work with Chan

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Whether you are buying your first home, selling, investing, or simply wondering whether it is too late for you (it is not), reach out. Chan typically responds within a few hours.

# A Note of Thanks

To the family and the church who sponsored strangers in 1980: everything in this book grew from your signature. To Mom and Dad: your courage is the first chapter of every story we will ever tell. To my sister: the fence, forever. To my husband and children: home is the people, and you are mine. And to the women who shared their kitchens, their questions, and their beginnings with me over twenty-five years: this book was always yours. I just wrote it down.

*This book shares personal experience and educational perspectives. It is not financial, legal, tax, or investment advice, and no outcome described here is a promise of your results. Real estate involves risk. Please consult qualified professionals about your own situation.*

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